

Ashruta Acharya

aachar3@gmu.edu

Ph.D. candidate in economics working at the intersection of comparative economic history, political economy, and development, with a regional focus on Nepal, India, and South Asia. My research examines how infrastructure, state capacity, institutions, and policy shocks shape long-run structural transformation, market integration, and spatial inequality. Trained in applied econometrics, geospatial analysis, and archival-policy research, I build original datasets and reproducible pipelines that connect historically grounded empirical work to broader questions in comparative economics.

Education

George Mason University <i>Ph.D. in Economics, Institutions & Development; Economic History</i>	Fairfax, VA <i>Expected Dec 2026</i>
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Wichita State University <i>M.A. in Applied Economics, GPA: 3.8</i>	Wichita, KS <i>May 2021</i>
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Wichita State University <i>B.B.A. in Economics, GPA: 3.6</i>	Wichita, KS <i>May 2019</i>
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Research Experience

Ph.D. Fellow & Research Assistant <i>George Mason University</i>	Aug 2021 – Present <i>Fairfax, VA</i>
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- Received a competitive \$160,000 four-year fellowship from the Mercatus Center to support doctoral research.
- Job Market Paper: constructed a new district-level historical panel for Nepal by digitizing road maps, harmonizing district boundaries, and linking road exposure to census outcomes across 74 districts, 1971–2011.
- Current empirical design uses staggered difference-in-differences based on districts' first exposure to the primary road network to study structural transformation, literacy, and the spatial distribution of economic opportunity.
- Preliminary findings suggest clearer medium-run effects on structural transformation than on literacy, consistent with the view that road integration first expanded market and occupational opportunities before broader human-capital gains fully emerged.
- Supported faculty research for Dr. Mark Koyama through literature synthesis, historical interpretation, and empirical data work.
- Applied Python, R, STATA, QGIS, ArcGIS Pro, and text-as-data / ML workflows to streamline data construction, cleaning, analysis, and drafting.

Graduate Research Assistant <i>Institute for the Study of Economic Growth, Wichita State University</i>	Jun 2019 – May 2021 <i>Wichita, KS</i>
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- Conducted faculty-directed research under Ted Bolema and Patricia Bradley at the Institute for the Study of Economic Growth.
- Delivered empirical and policy research support through data collection, statistical analysis, literature synthesis, and drafting of macroeconomic and applied-economics memoranda.

Research Intern, Center for Economic Policy <i>Institute for Integrated Development Studies</i>	Feb 2021 – Aug 2021 <i>Kathmandu, Nepal</i>
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- Supported an IFPRI-related policy report through literature review, data cleaning, and production of figures and summary materials for development stakeholders.
- Co-authored *Trade Flow Patterns in Nepal*, published as Feed the Future Research Paper 7 (October 2021), on agricultural trade in a developing economy.

Teaching & Professional Experience

Graduate Lecturer <i>Department of Economics, George Mason University</i>	May 2023 – Present <i>Fairfax, VA</i>
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- Instructor of record for Economic History, Intermediate Macroeconomics, Money & Banking, and Economics for the Citizen (20–35 students per section).
- Designed syllabi, lectures, assessments, and feedback systems, and introduced supplemental econometrics and AI-prompting training to strengthen students' workplace readiness.
- Proactively scaffolded intermediate courses with targeted review of macro principles to close preparation gaps and improve student performance.

Founding President

Society of Nepali Women in Economics (SONWE)

Jun 2020 – Dec 2021

Kathmandu, Nepal

- Founded and led a professional network of 10+ emerging economists, building programming around mentorship, public events, and research visibility.
- Organized the major event *Women in Nepali Economic Growth* and established organizational direction that expanded SONWE into an active platform for women in economics in Nepal.

Graduate Fellow

American Institute for Economic Research

Feb 2024 – Apr 2024

Great Barrington, MA

- Developed dissertation-related research in institutions and development while engaging faculty and public audiences through talks and policy-facing writing.

Publications

Acharya, A., Geloso, V., & Psurek, A. *The Hole in the Doughnut: Formalizing and Testing a Key Model of Degrowth*. Contemporary Economic Policy, April 2026.

Neopane, A., Nepal, B., & Acharya, A. *Trade Flow Patterns in Nepal*. Feed the Future (USAID), Research Paper 7, October 2021.

Working Papers & Research in Progress

Roads, State Integration, and Uneven Development in Modern Nepal

Job Market Paper

District-level historical panel for Nepal combining digitized road maps, harmonized district boundaries, and census outcomes to study staggered primary-road exposure and medium-run structural transformation.

Market Access and Road-Led Development in Nepal

Dissertation Chapter in Progress

Uses least-cost transport paths and district populations to estimate changes in market access and analyze the intensity channel through which road integration affected local development.

Regmi Research Series dataset building with ML

Research in Progress

India–Nepal Trade Exposure under the GST

Research in Progress

The Political Economy of the 1854 *Muluki Ain*

Research in Progress

References

Dr. Mark Koyama (Advisor)

mark.koyama@gmail.com

Dr. Alex Tabarrok

atabarro@gmu.edu

Dr. Tyler Cowen

tcowen@gmu.edu

Dr. Vincent Geloso

vgeloso@gmu.edu

Technical Skills

Quantitative Methods: Applied econometrics, panel data methods, staggered difference-in-differences, spatial econometrics, geospatial data construction, time-series analysis, data visualization, text-as-data analysis.

Software: STATA, Python, R, ArcGIS Pro, Excel, LaTeX, Codex-assisted scripting for research automation and pipeline development.

Communication: Clear written and oral communication for academic, policy, and classroom audiences.

Languages: English (fluent), Nepali (native), Hindi (fluent), Korean (beginner).